Credit: revolutionwatch

Hamilton Pulsar Time Computer

Of course, once the computer was wearable, it was only a matter of time (pun definitely intended) before manufacturers started adding new features. The calculator was among the first new features that was added to watches. I choose to believe that this was developed specifically to spite teachers who said that we wouldn't carry calculators everywhere. But that's just me. A notable watch series was the Casio Databank that built upon the calculator by offering additional features like a phone book, memos and even touch screens.

Then in 1982, Seiko decided to not just raise the bar, but punch it into orbit. The Seiko T001 had a display that let users watch friggin' TV on it! It had a tiny 1.2-inch LCD monochrome display and users had to hook it up to an external receiver to watch anything. But who cares! It was possible for people to watch TV on their wrist in 1982. For context, this was before India even won a cricket World Cup!

The `90s saw the final pieces of the jigsaw put into place. Launched in 1994, the Timex DataLink allowed users to wirelessly transfer data like appointments and such from their Microsoft PCs. This is something most modern smartwatches still need

Credit: Historictech

Seiko T001 TV Watch

a cable for. Timex and Microsoft's solution was brilliant. Data is transmitted from the PC to the watch via pulsating horizontal flashes on the CRT monitor. A small optical sensor on top of the watch would read this information and translate the data. Why are things so needlessly complicated now?

The new millenium would finally see all this technology finally come together to create a working smartwatch. Just in time too as the new millennium would also see the debut of a certain technology magazine dedicated to covering all the major happenings in tech (Hint: You're reading it right now).

THE SMARTWATCH RISES

The 20-odd years search since the start of the millennium (and Digit magazine) would see the rise of smart technology and rapid advancement in technology. From smartphones to laptops, things would (and are) evolving at a rapid pace. However, things on the wearable side of things were pretty slow in the beginning. The smartwatch as we know it really started to get together in the early-to-mid 2010s. But there were a few bright spots before that.

The ~~Apple Watch~~ IBM Watchpad

In 2001, IBM partnered with Citizen to develop a wearable called the Watchpad. The device would feature an in-built speaker and microphone, with connectivity options such as Bluetooth. Users could interact with the device via buttons, touchscreen, and a small crown, which could be rotated to scroll through menu options. It was tipped to launch at $399. OK... why the heck does it feel like I'm just talking about the Apple Watch! However, there is one major difference between the IBM Watchpad and the Apple Watch. The latter would actually be released, while the Watchpad would remain a prototype. Oh, what could have been...

Missed a SPOT

Three years later, in 2004, Microsoft unveiled a SPOT, which stands for

Credit: IBM

IBM WatchPad

Smart Personal Object Technology. Besides being possibly the worst backronym in technology, SPOT was essentially a framework that allowed devices to receive updates like news, weather, even emails and instant messages. It did this via the magic of FM radio signals and Microsoft figured that it would sell the service as a subscription. While SPOT could be added to pretty much any device, watches were the key category and some major names like Suunto, Fossils and more would develop devices with SPOT. As a result, Microsoft would go on to lead the wearable category. JUST KIDDING! The product was a major failure and the company would quietly discontinue the service by the end of the decade. However, it did showcase the possible user benefits of a wearable that's constantly updated with live information.

Watch this

In 2007, a year before the launch of the Apple iPhone, Sony unveiled the Sony Ericsson MBW-150. This was a hybrid device with a tiny monochrome display. The watch would pair with your phone and would display things like caller ID and text. It was one of the early examples of a wearable being used as an accessory

Credit: joewilcox

Microsoft SPOT powered Suunto n3